

Which Open Source licence is for you?

Even if you're not a developer, but are curious about how Open Source stays free, this is a must-read. But say you're thinking of building or are in the process of building an Open Source application. Which licence you should go for depends a lot on what your goals are. Read on to unravel the labyrinth of FOSS licences, and get one that fits your needs perfectly*

Siddharth Parwatay
siddharth.parwatay@9dot9.in

The world of Open Source is guided by a philosophy and is strongly bound by principles. The righteousness that permeates the far corners of this world is so strong that even when non-coders think of the subject, there's an inner glow they feel about being on the side of something that's not evil, something that has honour, a way of life that stands for something. Yes, when you install VLC or tinker around in Audacity you feel it too; it's like belonging to a movement and par-

taking vicariously in that collective warm fuzzy feeling. Ever wonder why that is? And what is it that keeps Free and Open Source Software (FOSS) what it is – open and free? Well, since we're laying it on so thick you've probably guessed it – yup it's the licences that govern the mechanisms of FOSS.

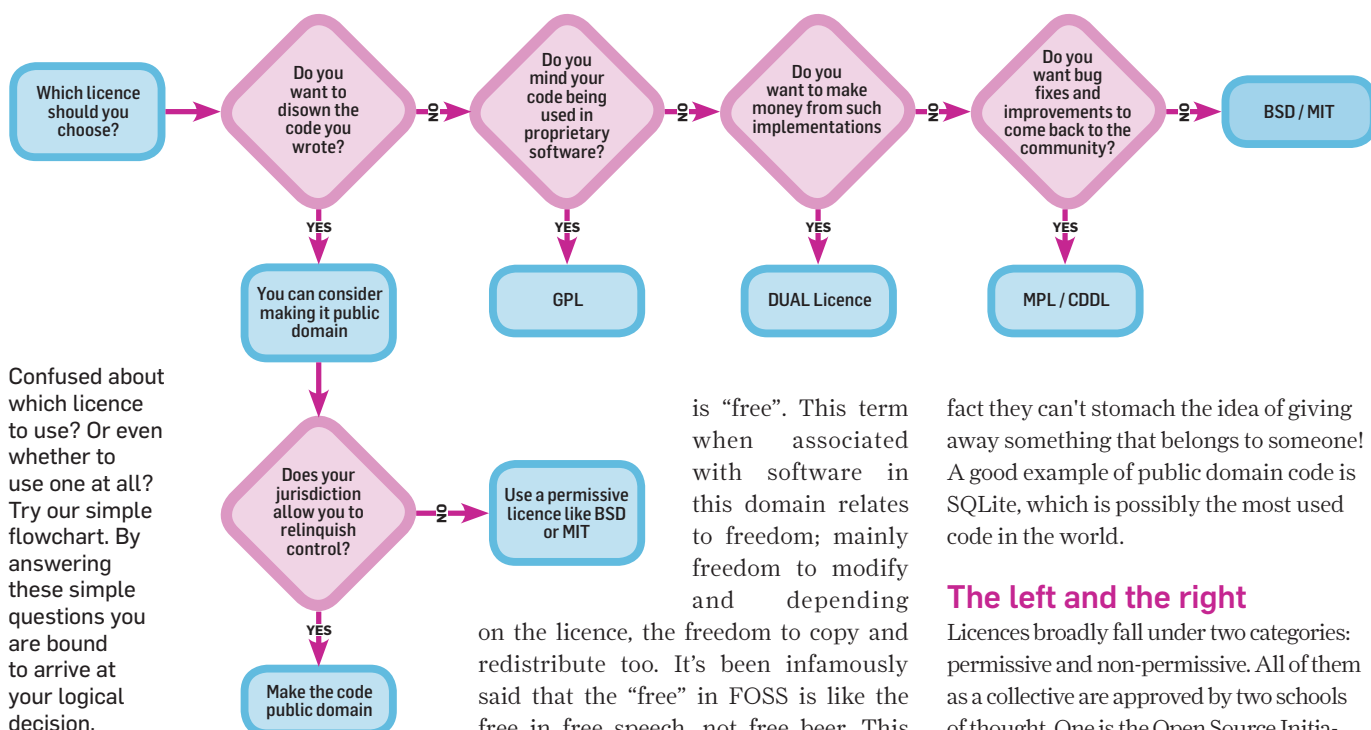
How do they do that? By being the guardians of the philosophy and protectors of the code creators' intentions. To understand this, we need to first delve into a bit of history which will also help us understand a few of the terms involved. The first and the foremost term (and perhaps the most often misused one)

means that free software is different from freeware and ergo Open Source need not always be free of cost. Surprised? It's true. The licensing framework is what allows some individuals and companies to make money off Open Source. The much-talked about dual-licensing model is one way to ensure that.

The poles of the spectrum

Now that we're getting to the actual licences part, it's important to understand the spectrum of licences that can exist. On one end, we have public domain code that has no copyright, while on the other end there is proprietary code. Public domain means that the creator of the software has relinquished his copyright over the code. In between the two poles we have licences like the Berkeley Software Distribution (BSD), GNU General Public licence (GPL) and various others. Some are closer (in the rights that they grant) to public domain while some are closer to proprietary or Closed Source software.

It's interesting to note that some countries, especially in the European Union, don't recognize the concept of public domain. The rationale is that if you wrote it, you're the author and treating that as a



The left and the right

Licences broadly fall under two categories: permissive and non-permissive. All of them as a collective are approved by two schools of thought. One is the Open Source Initia-